



Investigation report

Rejected take-off and runway overrun, Tarlton Springs - Executive brief

Drafted 29/09/2026

INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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What happened

On 18 June 2026, Saltbush Air flight SB512, a 50-seat twin-turboprop aircraft registered VH-SBQ, was preparing to depart runway 09 at Tarlton Springs Aerodrome in the hour after last light. On board were 44 passengers, 2 flight crew and 1 cabin crew. The aerodrome operator had carried out its only runway inspection of the day at 21:35 UTC on the previous day, before the first scheduled arrival, and recorded the movement area as clear. No further inspection was carried out or requested. At 07:29:10 UTC, the tower cleared the aircraft for take-off with the wind reported as 090 degrees at 6 kt. The tower did not offer a runway inspection and the crew did not request one. No transmission about wildlife was made on the tower channel in the preceding 90 minutes. The first officer was flying the aircraft. The take-off roll began at 07:30:02 with both engines producing matching power, and the calculated V1 of 112 kt was called at 07:30:29.

Two seconds later, the first officer saw two kangaroos crossing the runway from the northern side to the southern side and called "Roos - roos, roos, on the left". The kangaroos were first seen at an estimated range of around 200 m. At 07:30:32, the captain took control and rejected the take-off at 118 kt, which was 6 kt and 3 seconds past V1, with 695 m of sealed runway remaining. The power levers reached flight idle within 0.6 seconds. About a second later, the aircraft struck both animals. The right (No. 2) propeller was damaged, and reverse thrust on that engine was unavailable for the rest of the stop. Maximum braking was established 2 seconds after the decision to reject, compared with a fleet average of 3.2 seconds. The anti-skid system was active on all four wheels, and reverse thrust was selected on the left (No. 1) engine at 07:30:36. The aircraft left the end of the sealed runway at approximately 21 kt at 07:30:51. It came to rest at 07:30:57, upright and on the extended centreline, 62 m into the 90 m runway end safety area. It stopped 28 m short of the end of the prepared area, beyond which the ground is ungraded. There was no fire.

At the captain's request, the tower activated the aerodrome emergency plan at 07:32:10. The crew did not command an evacuation. Passengers left the aircraft by the forward airstair between 07:34:40 and 07:38:48. No one was seriously injured. One cabin crew member reported bruising sustained during the disembarkation. The aircraft was substantially damaged. The damage included:

- three No. 2 propeller blades damaged beyond limits
- distorted right main landing gear doors
- both right main tyres deflated
- punctures to the lower right fuselage

Both kangaroos were killed. The aerodrome was closed for 4 hours 20 minutes.

Why it happened

The overrun resulted from a take-off rejected above V1 after two kangaroos moved onto the runway. In the stop that followed, the aircraft could not decelerate as well as its scheduled accelerate-stop performance assumed.

It is very likely that the two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface during the take-off roll. It is extremely likely that their presence led both to the strike and to the decision to reject. The captain rejected the take-off 6 kt above V1, and it is extremely likely that this contributed to the aircraft decelerating less than its scheduled accelerate-stop performance. The strike on the No. 2 propeller and right main gear also contributed, which is virtually certain. It is virtually certain that the reduced deceleration resulted in the aircraft leaving the sealed runway and entering the runway end safety area.

The decision to reject above V1 was shaped by training. Rejected take-off training covered only aircraft system failures below V1 (Safety issue), and it is likely that this influenced the decision.

Three conditions came together to put the kangaroos on the runway:

- Repair of the aerodrome perimeter fence had been deferred for three budget cycles (Safety issue). It is very likely this contributed to the animals reaching the runway.
- The aircraft departed in the hour after last light, which is the peak of kangaroo movement. This likely contributed.
- No runway inspection was requested before this first departure after last light. This likely contributed.

The absence of an inspection was not simply an individual omission. A runway inspection was required only at listed aerodromes, and the criterion for listing was that a strike had occurred there (Safety issue). It is very likely that this contributed to no inspection being requested. How the evening service was introduced also influenced that arrangement. The service was approved as a schedule change, and the route risk assessment was not reopened (Safety issue). It is likely that this contributed.

More broadly, a documented wildlife plan was required only above a size threshold that the aerodrome did not meet (Safety issue). It is likely that this contributed both to the fence repair being deferred and to the inspection arrangement described above.

Once the take-off was rejected, the crew applied maximum braking and No. 1 reverse without delay. It is very likely that this contributed to the aircraft coming to rest within the runway end safety area.

The investigation also examined whether reduced runway edge lighting intensity limited the crew's ability to see the animals. A measured deviation in lighting intensity was confirmed, and it was in a location relevant to the sighting. However, whether it affected the crew's ability to detect the animals was about as likely as not. It could not be established either way with the evidence available, so no conclusion is drawn. [NOT ESTABLISHED: what further evidence would be needed to resolve the lighting question]

What we found

Contributing safety factors

- A documented wildlife plan was required only above a size threshold that the aerodrome does not meet. It is virtually certain that this existed, and likely that it contributed. (Safety issue)
- Repair of the perimeter fence was deferred for three budget cycles. It is virtually certain that this existed, and very likely that it contributed. (Safety issue)
- Two kangaroos entered the runway strip and moved onto the sealed surface. It is very likely that this existed, and very likely that it contributed.
- The take-off was rejected 6 kt above V1. It is virtually certain that this existed, and very likely that it contributed.
- The deceleration achieved was below the scheduled accelerate-stop performance. It is virtually certain that this existed, and virtually certain that it contributed.
- The aircraft departed in the hour after last light, which is the peak of kangaroo movement. It is very likely that this existed, and likely that it contributed.
- A runway inspection was required only at listed aerodromes, and the listing criterion was a strike. It is virtually certain that this existed, and very likely that it contributed. (Safety issue)
- No runway inspection was requested before the first departure after last light. It is virtually certain that this existed, and likely that it contributed.
- The evening service was approved as a schedule change, and the route risk assessment was not reopened. It is very likely that this existed, and likely that it contributed. (Safety issue)
- Rejected take-off training covered aircraft system failures below V1 only. It is very likely that this existed, and likely that it contributed. (Safety issue)
- The No. 2 propeller and right main gear struck two kangaroos. It is virtually certain that this existed, and virtually certain that it contributed.

Other factors that increased risk

- Part of the cabin floor proximity emergency lighting was unserviceable. It is virtually certain that this existed, and very likely that it increased risk. (Safety issue)
- The flight was the fifth sector of the day, 11 hours into the crew's duty and 40 minutes behind schedule. It is virtually certain that this existed, and likely that it increased risk.

Other findings

- The investigation examined whether the take-off began with a tailwind above limits, and ruled it out.
- The investigation examined whether the No. 2 engine lost power during the take-off roll, and ruled it out.
- The investigation examined the crew's application of maximum braking and No. 1 reverse without delay, and found that it reduced risk.

What is being done

Documented wildlife plan required only above a size threshold the aerodrome does not meet. Tarlton Springs was not in breach of Aerodrome Standard AS-139. The issue lies in the threshold itself, which left an aerodrome of this size without a documented, audited wildlife programme. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any action taken or proposed in response to this issue, and by whom]

Perimeter fence repair deferred for three budget cycles. The failed northern fence section remains recorded in the aerodrome works register under items WR-221 and WR-263. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the fence repair has since been funded, scheduled or completed]

Evening service approved as a schedule change, route risk assessment not reopened. On 19 June 2026, the Head of Flying Operations suspended the evening Tarlton Springs service. No action has been recorded on the change management process or on route risk assessment RRA-041. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the suspension remains in place, and any action on the change management process or RRA-041]

Runway inspection required only at listed aerodromes, and the listing criterion is a strike. On 2 July 2026, the investigation raised this issue with the operator's Safety Department. It identified two problems. Only a reported strike at an aerodrome can place it on the list, and no provision asks crews to report sightings. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the Safety Department's response and any action taken or proposed]

Rejected take-off training covers aircraft system failures below V1 only. No action has been recorded against this issue. [NOT ESTABLISHED: any action taken or proposed on the training syllabus or Operations Manual Part B 4.6]

Cabin floor proximity emergency lighting partially unserviceable. The investigation has referred the question of whether the same failed ballast affects the rest of the fleet to engineering, and that answer is pending. No action has been recorded on the 24-month functional test interval. [NOT ESTABLISHED: the outcome of the fleet-wide engineering review and any action on the test interval]

Distribution

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